The Beginning

The indigenous population of Sri Lanka (formerly Ceylon) consists largely of elements that had migrated from India over various periods of the distant past. However, in modern times, systematic labour migration from India to Sri Lanka began in the 1830s. Yet, the stream of workers from south India, which greatly increased between the 1830s and 1880s, was never assimilated into the island's permanent population. The collapse of the coffee industry in the 1890s led to a sharp decline in the migration of labour from India and during the period 1931 to 1946, the Indian labour population registered a sharp decrease following a 1939 ban imposed by the government of India on the emigration of unskilled labour. The majority of the Indian labour, which overwhelmingly came from south India, was concentrated in the tea and rubber estates. The proximity of the migrants' homes in India and the lack of contact with the local population resulted in the emergence of an immigrant Indian community as a separate part of the Ceylonese permanent population, but at the same time as an unassimilated minority. This had political consequences when Ceylon gradually acquired responsible and elected government under British administration, long before the country became independent in 1948. After independence, the Ceylonese government took several administrative and legislative measures to regulate and control the rights of the Indian population.

The question of the status of Indians in Ceylon became a matter of negotiations between the independent governments of India and Ceylon. Discussions between the two sides in 1947-48 did not yield concrete results. After several years of negotiations, the two countries concluded an agreement in 1964 regarding